

A slice of student involvement

How Innovation Brew Works incorporates students in every step

By Lindsey Lam and Lola Hertsenberg

(Communication values: Connection, synergy)

When walking into the establishment, the smell of freshly baked pizza and spilt beer floats through the air. Chatter of students and locals hum throughout the building, and the sound of beer taps trickle between each conversation.

For many college students, this experience awaits them either off campus or after they turn 21 and begin visiting bars. And, for most college students, their pizza options are few and far between, usually of dining hall pizza or fast-food pizza.

For Cal Poly Pomona students, however, there is another option less than a mile from campus.

Innovation Brew Works is CPP's on-campus brewery and brewpub that focuses on student involvement, local ingredients, and hands-on learning, embodying the university's motto:

"Become by Doing."

IBW serves more than just pizza, though. The brewpub serves locally brewed beer, sandwiches, salads, and sodas. Due to the convenient location, the restaurant serves the local community and students from nearby colleges and high schools.

"What I have noticed from like my past years is that students don't really know that they're able to come here because they think beer and they think 21," IBW manager Valerie Valenzuela said.

"So, they forget we like sell pizza and that we have events."

IBW started in 2014 as [a collaborative project](#) between the Collins College of Hospitality and the Don B. Huntley College of Agriculture to provide hands-on experience in brewing and restaurant operations.

Since 2015, the establishment has been featured in [more than 300](#) major news outlets.

IBW's process of serving the public starts long before the restaurant opens its doors each day.

Ingredients for IBW are grown on campus by students from the Don B. Huntley College of Agriculture and delivered once a week, according to Valenzuela.

Prep cooks like architecture student Isabel Migoya then receive the ingredients and handle them during morning shifts to prepare the restaurant for opening.

"The ingredients we use in the beer are from the Spadra Farm," Migoya said. "We get the basil from the vertical farm."

Migoya's role goes beyond the kitchen. Being trained in every front-of-house position, she finds herself working several different roles in her shifts. She helps arrange tables and chairs, stocks cooking supplies, and makes sure the restaurant is ready to serve customers. Most importantly, however, the dough is the star of the show and takes the most time to season and prepare, according to Migoya.

Yet, even after a year of working at IBW, Migoya still hasn't grown tired of the food she helps prepare throughout the week.

"I think IBW is better than Little Caesar's," Migoya said. "Like it is better in every possible way."

Once the prep cooks finish setting the restaurant up, the ropes drop and the pacing shifts. Orders begin coming in, and sandwiches, salads, and pizzas are all made fresh, one at a time. The made-to-order approach may cause longer wait times than other pizza chains, but many say the quality is worth the wait.

Biology student Audrey Paik is one of those customers. She visits the establishment about once a month for chicken buffalo wings and pizza.

“I really appreciate how it’s better than other places and it’s closer to campus,” Paik said.

Yet, while the made-to-order pizzas promise to be fresh and tasty, some students like psychology student Kuuipo Kalipi still can’t get behind the brewpub. Despite living on campus and being just a quarter-mile away from IBW, Kalipi still makes the drive to the nearby Domino’s Pizza for her pizza fix.

“I feel more comfortable eating at Domino’s because I grew up eating it and the variety of the toppings is better,” Kalipi said.

Kalipi uses the online app to order ahead and pick up to avoid long waits at the establishment. IBW, on the other hand, only offers call-in or Grubhub orders, both of which Kalipi tries to avoid. She also enjoys the delivery option with Domino’s for when she’s busy studying in her dorm.

While IBW might not appeal to every Bronco, its reach extends beyond the college community. Pomona and Walnut locals also visit the brewpub, according to Valenzuela.

Game showings, trivia nights, and student-performed live music regularly draw big crowds to the restaurant, said Migoya. On warm evenings, many passersby can see groups of customers gathering on the patio enjoying a slice of pizza and a glass of cold beer.

“I think it's really cool what we're doing here,” Valenzuela said. “We’re able to just work with the campus community and then still work with the campus outside.”

Valerie Valenzuela – vbvalenzuela@cpp.edu

Kuuipo Kalipi – kpkalipi@cpp.edu

Audrey Paik – aipaik@cpp.edu